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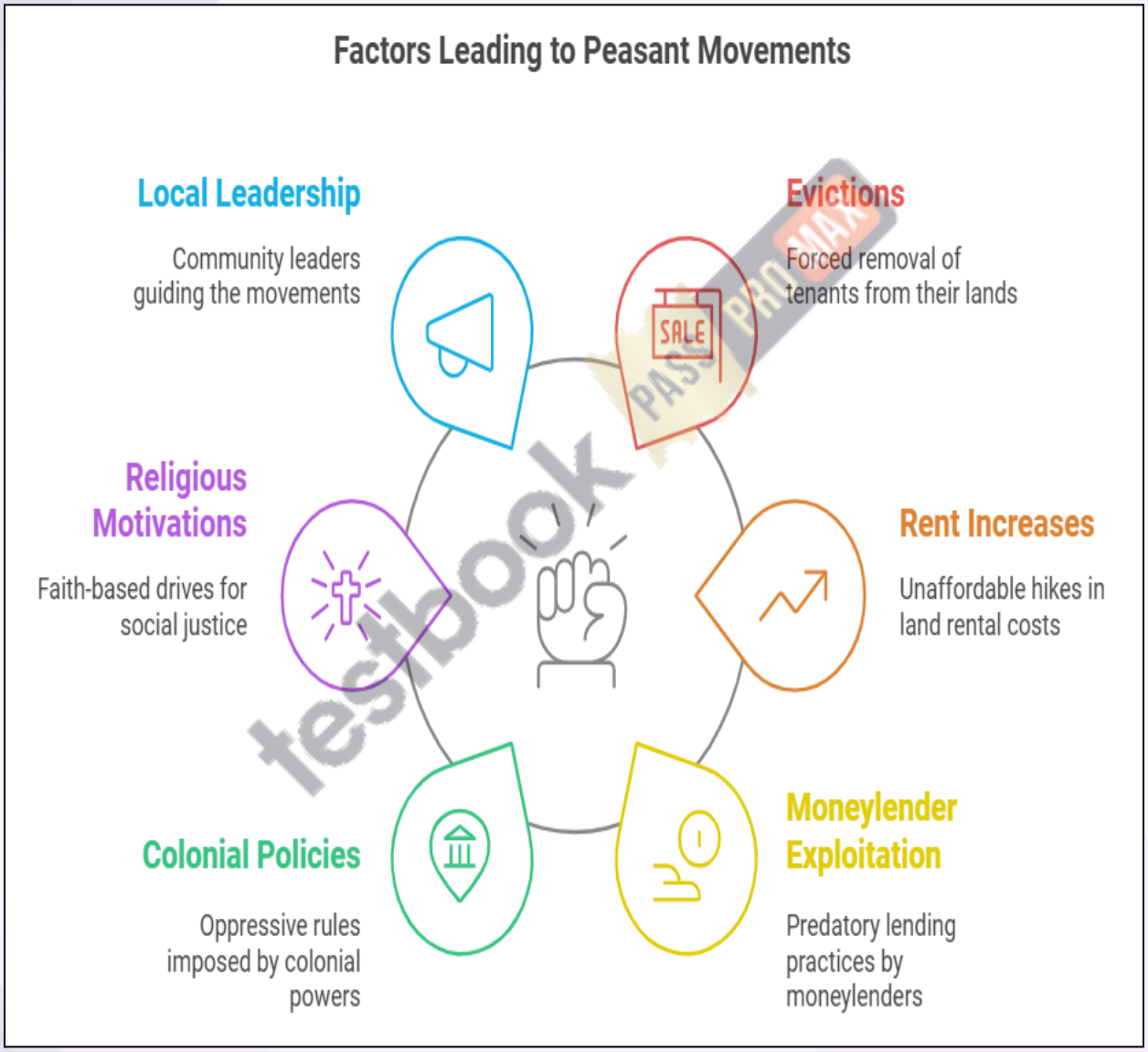
General Knowledge
Modern History

STUDY NOTES

Peasant Movements

Peasant Movements

Peasant uprisings were **protests against evictions, increases in the rents of land, and the moneylenders' greedy ways**. Their **aim** was **occupancy rights for peasants** among other things. They were revolts and rebellions of the peasants themselves though **led by local leaders** in many cases.



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Key Peasant Movements in India: A Historical Timeline

1782-1831
Narkelberia Uprising in West Bengal

1825-1835
Pagal Panthis Movement in Meghalaya

1838-1857
Faraizi Revolt in Eastern Bengal

1836-1854
Moplah Uprisings in Malabar

1859-1860
Indigo Revolt in Bengal

1875
Deccan Riots in Maharashtra

1873-1885
Pabna Movement in Bengal

1917-1918
Champaran Movement in Bihar

1921
Eka Movement in Awadh

1946-1952
Telangana Movement in Andhra Pradesh

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Narkelberia Uprising (1782-1831):

- **Region - West Bengal.**
- **Leaders - Mir Nithar Ali or Titu Mir.**
- Revolt - **Muslim tenants in West Bengal rose against landlords, mainly Hindu**, who imposed a **beard tax** on the Faraizis, and British indigo planters.
- The revolt later **merged into the Wahabi movement.**

The Pagal Panthis (1825 to 1835):

- **Region - Meghalaya region (earlier in Bengal).**
- **Leaders - Karam Shah.**
- The **Pagal Panthi is a semi-religious group** mainly constituting the Hajong and Garo tribes.
- From 1825 to 1835, the **Pagal Panthis refused to pay rent above a certain limit and attacked the houses of zamindars.**
- The government introduced an **equitable arrangement to protect these peasants, but the movement was violently suppressed**.

Faraizi Revolt (1838 to 1857):

- **Region - Faridpur in Eastern Bengal.**
- **Leaders - Dadu Mian.**
- The **Faraizis** were the followers of a **Muslim sect founded by Haji Shariat-Allah.**
- They advocated **radical religious, social, and political changes.**
- They **aimed** to **expel the English intruders** from Bengal.
- The sect also supported the cause of the tenants against the zamindars.
- Most of the **Faraizis joined the Wahabi ranks.**

Moplah Uprisings (1836 to 1854):

- **Region - Malabar.**
- **Reasons- hike in revenue demand and reduction of field size, coupled with the oppression of officials.**
- **Twenty-two rebellions** took place between 1836 and 1854. None, however, proved successful.

- The s**econd Moplah uprising occurred** after the Moplahs came to be organized by the Congress and the Khilafat supporters **during the Non-cooperation Movement**

Indigo Revolt (1859-60)

- **Region: Bengal**
- **Leader: Biswas brothers (Bishnucaharan Biswas and Digambar Biswas)** of Nadia, Rafique Mondal of Malda and Kader Molla of Pabna.
- **Reason for the revolt:** The peasants in many parts of Bengal had refused to plant indigo for the European planters who had been forcing the peasants to cultivate it. The Bengali intellectuals brought this issue to the notice of the Indian public.
- **Nature of the revolt:** The peasants attacked indigo factories with spears and swords.
- Planters who demanded rent were beaten.
- It was especially strong in the Pabna district, where the ryots were strongly opposed to sowing indigo.
- The Government appointed the **Indigo Commission in 1869**, which worked for the removal of some of the abuses of indigo cultivation.
- The play **Neel Darpan by Dinabandhu Mitra in 1860** depicted planters' oppression and peasants' protests.

Deccan Riots (1875):

- **Region: Poona, Satara, and Ahmednagar**
- **Reason for the revolt:** The basis of the Deccan Riots lay in the **evolution of the ryotwari system** itself. By favoring the **Vanis (village moneylenders) over the Kunbis (cultivator caste)**, the courts and new laws polarised caste differences.
- This implied an increase in the transfer of holdings from peasants to moneylenders.
- The Kunbis rose against the Vanis in order to dispossess them of their title deeds and mortgage bonds, which were looked upon as instruments of oppression.
- **Nature of the revolt:** The peasantry, which had gathered for the weekly bazaar, launched attacks on the moneylenders and destroyed the debt contracts and bonds.
- After suppressing the revolt, the Government passed the **Deccan Agriculturists Relief Act in 1879** to extend protection to them against the moneylenders.

Pabna Movement(1873-1885):

- **Region: Pabna, Bengal**
- **Leader: Ishan Chandra Roy, Shambhu Nath Pal, Khodi Mulla.**
- **Reason for the revolt:** The peasants organised a **no-rent union** and launched armed attacks on the zamindars and their agents because of the **illegal seizure of property, arbitrary enhancement of rent and use of force**, frequent recourses to ejection and harassment,
- The Act of 1859 provided ryots with immunity from eviction. The attempts of zamindars to annihilate the tenant's newly acquired occupancy rights and to convert them into tenants at will through forcibly written agreement resulted in harassment and atrocities that were vehemently opposed by peasants.
- **Agrarian League (1873)**, organized by peasants of **Yusufshahi Pargana of Pabna**, which raised funds to mitigate litigation expenses, held mass meetings.
- This peasant movement was suppressed only after armed intervention by the government. Later an enquiry committee was appointed to look into the complaints of the peasants, which led to the enactment of an act.

Champaran Movement(1917-1918):

- **Region: Champaran, Bihar**
- **Leader: Mahatma Gandhi, assisted by J.B. Kripalani, Babu Brajkishore Prasad, and Babu Rajendra Prasad.**
- Reason for the revolt: The tenant farmers were forced by the British planters to **cultivate indigo in the three-twentieth part of a bigha of their holding**; this was known as the **'Teen Kathia' system**.
- Losses were transferred to poor peasants, or they could give up indigo cultivation by paying higher rents for the land.
- Nature of the revolt: Gandhiji's method of **peaceful satyagraha and civil disobedience**.
- The government had to relent and called Gandhiji for talks and also made him a member of the committee to enquire into the plight of the indigo peasants.
- The Teen Kathia system was abolished based on the committee's report.

Kheda Satyagraha (1918):

- **Region: Kheda, Gujarat**
- **Leader: Mahatma Gandhi**
- **Reason for the revolt:** The immediate backdrop to the agitation was a poor harvest in 1917-18, which coincided with an increase in the price of essentials.
- The peasants demanded a remission of revenue for the year to alleviate their suffering, but the colonial government ignored their concerns.
- Getting no assurance from the government on the demands of peasants, Gandhi decided at a meeting of the Gujarat Sabha to resort to Satyagraha.
- Nature of the revolt: Reports of violence in some areas disobeying Gandhi's appeal to passive resistance.
- Mohanlal Kameshwar Pandya and other local leaders were arrested for defying the government.
- The government ordered its local officials to be restrained in the collection of revenues and not to confiscate lands because they wanted Indian support in British war efforts.

Eka Movement(1921):

- **Region: Awadh, Uttar Pradesh**
- **Leader: Madari Pasi**
- **The revolt in Uttar Pradesh was led by Fiji-returned indentured labourer Baba Ramachandra.**
- Reason for the revolt: **Spanish flu, six years of drought, price rise, and a shortage of food, grains, and fuel**.
- Charging higher than the recorded rent,
- Non-distribution of rent receipts, imposition of additional and arbitrary cesses,
- Grain rents are more prevalent than cash rents,
- Practice of nazrana (advance additional payment as service), hari, begari (forced labour),
- Corruption by middlemen like thekedars and karindas (agents of landlords).
- Nature of the revolt: Because of the involvement of Congress and Khilafat campaigners, the movement was initially largely peaceful and worked within the framework of Gandhian ideology.

- Social boycott (sweepers, barbers, and washermen), picketing and holding mass rallies to push for their demands.
- However, as the movement became more militant and began to aggressively resist Taluqdar and Zamindar violence, the Congress and Khilafat leaders distanced themselves from it, and this peasant movement became completely independent of Congress-Khilafat influence.

Mappila Revolt (1921):

- **Region: Malabar region, Kerala**
- **Reason for the revolt: Nambudiri Brahmin landlords exploited the Mappila tenants**. This rebellion had started as an anti-government, anti-landlord affair but acquired communal colours.
- The new land laws enacted by the British government in the nineteenth century gave landlords, the majority of whom were upper-caste Hindus, sole legal ownership of the land. The Moplahs had been deprived of their formal or customary rights, which they had held for a long time.
- **In Manjeri in 1920, the Malabar District Congress Committee** supported the tenants' cause and demanded legislation to regulate landlord-tenant relations.
- Nature of the revolt: The uprising reportedly led to the death of around 10,000 people. Many Hindus were forced to convert to Islam.
- In one incident, Moplah prisoners died of suffocation while being taken to the Central Prison in Podanur in a closed railway wagon. The incident is widely known as the **"Wagon Tragedy".**
- The uprising lasted several months, forcing British authorities to impose martial law to put an end to it. They also established a new police unit called the Malabar Special Police to put down the rebellion.

Bardoli Satyagraha(1928):

- **Region: Gujarat**
- **Leader: Vallabhbhai Patel**
- **Reason for the revolt:** Against the tax hike of 22% by the Bombay Presidency in the backdrop of famine and flood.

- **Demands of the Peasants:** Either the government appoints an independent tribunal for a fresh assessment, or it must accept the previous amount as the full payment.
- Methods used for mobilizing the masses: Bardoli Satyagraha Patrika was a daily newspaper published during the satyagraha.
- The other methods used were **bhajan mandali, holy imagery and 'bhuvas' (used to communicate with Adivasis)**.
- During this time, Vallabhbhai Patel, who was given the moniker **"Sardar" by the women who participated in the movement**, emerged as a national leader.
- Under the pressure of the Satyagrahis, the government had begun to run out of steam by June 1928. A settlement with the farmers was mediated by **Chunnilal Mehta**, a key member of the **Governor's Council**.
- He proposed a 5.7% increase, and land confiscated by the administration would be returned upon payment of this tax.
- In the meantime, those who resigned from government jobs in support of the farmers would be reinstated.

All India Kisan Sabha(1936):

- **Formed at Indian National Congress (INC) Lucknow Session**
- **Founder: Swami Sahajananda Saraswati**
- Formation of All India Kisan Sabha: **In Bihar, Swami Sahajanand** started a movement to protect the occupancy rights of the tenants, and formed **Bihar Provincial Kisan Sabha in 1929**.
- **In Andhra, N.G. Ranga** also mobilised the peasants and formed a Kisan Sabha. The Kisan Sabha movement spread to other regions of the country also, and it raised the demand for the abolition of zamindari.
- At the Congress session in **Lucknow in 1936**, the **All India Kisan Sabha was formed, with Sahajanand as its first president**.
- **Manifesto:** It issued the **Kisan manifesto**, which called for the **abolition of zamindari and occupancy rights for all tenants**.
- **After the Elections of 1937:** The Congress ministries undertook certain measures to reduce the debt burdens by fixing interest rates in all provinces ruled by it, enhancements of rent were checked,

- In UP, cultivators were given the status of occupancy tenants. **In Bihar, bakhast lands were partly restored to tenants; in Maharashtra, the khoti tenants of landholders were given some rights**.
- Grazing fees on the forest lands were abolished.

Tebhaga Movement(1946–47):

- **Region: Bengal**
- **Organised by Communist cadres of the Bengal Provincial Krishak Sabha**.
- **Demand:** It was the sharecroppers' movement that demanded two-thirds of the land's produce for themselves and one-third for landlords.
- **Tebhaga literally means 'three shares' of harvests**. Traditionally, sharecroppers held their tenancy on a fifty-fifty basis of the produce. Sharecroppers were referred to as **bargadars, adhiars**, etc.
- The barga (sharecropping) peasants were mobilized against the landlord class under their leadership.
- The tenants who were resisting the Zamindari system added a new slogan to their campaign: the total abolition of the Zamindari system.
- **Outcomes**: Approximately **40% of sharecropping peasants obtained tebhaga rights** willingly granted by landholders, repeal or reduction of unjust and illegal exaction. However, the movement's success in East Bengal districts was limited.

Telangana Movement(1946-1952):

- **Region: Andhra Pradesh**
- **Against Oppressive landlordism perpetrated by local landlords (jagirdars and Deshmukh, locally known as Dora), which Nizam patronised.**
- Reasons: **Peasants were forced to pay high taxes** due to unhealthy economic policies of Nizam rule, and in non-payments of the taxes, they were subjected to **forced labour (Vetti)** and even forced to be evicted from their land.
- **Nature of the Revolt**: The Indian National Congress, **Andhra Jana Sangam, and Andhra Maha Sabha (AMS)** have raised the issue of Telangana's poor peasantry. Jagir RyotuSangham was formed in 1940 to bring pressure upon the government to solve the problems of the peasants working under the jagirdars.

- Later, the Guerrilla-styled armed struggle against both the landlords and razakars was adopted, for which the arms were provided by the Communist Party of India leadership.
- **Vetti was abolished, lands were distributed, debts were settled**, etc.